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|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|----------------------------|--|------|
| CANAL<br><b>BEAVER &amp; ERIE DIVISION, Pa. Canal</b>                                      |  | STATUS<br><b>Abandoned</b> |  | ACS  |
| STATE/PROVINCE: <b>Penna.</b>                                                              |  |                            |  | HAER |
| COUNTIES: <b>Beaver, Lawrence, Mercer, Crawford and Erie</b>                               |  |                            |  |      |
| LOCATION (Endpoints of Canal):<br><b>Beaver (on the Ohio River) to Erie (on Lake Erie)</b> |  |                            |  |      |
| TOPOGRAPHIC MAPS:                                                                          |  |                            |  |      |
| HISTORICAL SIGNIFICANCE:                                                                   |  |                            |  |      |
| PHYSICAL DESCRIPTION:                                                                      |  |                            |  |      |
| NAMES & ADDRESSES OF GROUPS CONCERNED WITH CANALS PRESENT                                  |  |                            |  |      |
| <b>Denver Walton, 968 Chapel Rd.<br/>Monaca, Pa. 15061</b>                                 |  |                            |  |      |
| BIBLIOGRAPHICAL SUMMARY:                                                                   |  |                            |  |      |
| <b>Walton has also written a number of individual articles on the Beaver-Erie Canal.</b>   |  |                            |  |      |
| UNPUBLISHED RECORDS, PHOTOS, DRAWINGS (CEHR, HAER, HABS)                                   |  |                            |  |      |
| EXISTING OR RECOMMENDED LANDMARK STATUS (CEHR, Nation)                                     |  |                            |  |      |
| REPORTER'S NAME & ADDRESS: <b>Wm. H. Shank, 81</b>                                         |  |                            |  |      |
| RETURN TO: <b>CANAL INDEX COMMITTEE, c/o</b>                                               |  |                            |  |      |

| ENLARGEMENTS | DATES IN USE | LENGTH |                  | LIFT LOCKS<br>No. / SIZE |
|--------------|--------------|--------|------------------|--------------------------|
|              |              | CANAL  | SLACKWATER TOTAL |                          |
| 1            | 1844-1871    | (Some) | 136              | 137 15x80                |
| 2            |              |        |                  |                          |
| 3            |              |        |                  |                          |
| 4            |              |        |                  |                          |

While the Main Line Systems and the Susquehanna Divisions were being planned, the people in Erie were also clamoring for the waterway connection to which the legislature had originally committed itself, which would tie in the city of Erie with the rest of the Pennsylvania Canal System. There was great disagreement about the route to be followed. Some people in the northwestern part of the state believed the water route should proceed from a point where the Western Division aqueduct crossed the Allegheny River at Freeport, northward along the Allegheny to Franklin, then up French Creek to Meadville and from there to Erie.

The people in Pittsburgh favored a route leaving the Ohio River downstream from Pittsburgh at Beaver and running through New Castle to Conneaut Lake and Erie, by way of the Beaver and Shenango Rivers. Pittsburghers felt that if the alternate route were chosen much of the Main Line traffic at Freeport would be directed to Erie without passing through Pittsburgh.

The State act of February 25, 1826 authorized the building of the French Creek feeder connecting Conneaut Lake, Meadville and Franklin. Work on this line was started before an ultimate decision was made regarding the main north-south connection to Erie.

Pittsburgh ultimately won out, and in 1831 a program of improvement was begun along the Beaver and Shenango Rivers as far north as Pulaski. This was known as the Beaver Division (31 miles).

In February of 1838 an extension from Pulaski northward to Conneaut Lake was approved, known as the Shenango Division, bringing the system 61 miles closer to Erie. In 1838 first contracts were awarded for the Conneaut Division to make final connection between Conneaut Lake and the city of Erie, an extension of 45 miles.

The state did not complete the Erie extension. In 1843, after spending more than \$4,000,000 on construction, the state turned over the whole Erie and Beaver canal project to the Erie Canal Company, headed by R. S. Reed of Erie. After investment of another half million dollars the canal was finally opened to traffic in October of 1844.

The 136 mile route of the Beaver and Erie canal required 137 locks to overcome a total rise of 977 feet. Locks were 15 x 80 feet, smaller than the Main Line standard. There were also at one time 13 dams, 9 aqueducts, 30 basins and 221 crossing road-bridges. Slackwater sections accounted for 32 miles of the route.

The Ohio River itself formed the junction between the Beaver and Erie Canal and the Main Line at Pittsburgh. Packet steamers went back and forth on the Ohio, and canal freight boats were routed from one canal to another with little inconvenience.

The Pennsylvania and Ohio Canal made connection with the Beaver and Erie Canal at New Castle, running 91 miles west to the Ohio and Erie Canal in Ohio. This Ohio connection, known as the "Cross-Cut Canal," was completed in 1840 and the primary products transported were pig iron and iron ore, as well as passengers between Pittsburgh and Cleveland.

Another short-lived connection between the Pennsylvania and Ohio canal systems was the Sandy and Beaver Canal, further south.